HISTORY · TWO PERSPECTIVES

Thanksgiving: Celebration or Controversy?

Explore one historical event through two different cultural perspectives.



Find the lie

Which statement is false?

1. Americans eat 46 million turkeys on Thanksgiving.
2. The first Thanksgiving celebration lasted three days.
3. Thanksgiving was created by the US government in 2001.



Vocabulary: Match the words

Match 1–5 with definitions A–E.

Words

1. harvest
2. gratitude
3. settler
4. trauma
5. perspective

Definitions

A. A person who moves to a new place to live.

B. The process of gathering crops (food) from the fields.

C. The ability to understand how someone else feels or sees the world.

D. A feeling of being thankful and grateful.

E. A very difficult or painful experience that affects someone for a long time.

Compare the perspectives

Complete the table with your partner.

Question	Traditional view	Native American view
What does the story focus on?	What are people thankful for?	What does the story focus on?
How are the settlers described?	How are the settlers described?	How are the settlers described?
Both views	What people, events, or ideas appear in both stories?	

Use these words: harvest · gratitude · trauma · perspective

READING · NOTICE THE LENS

Reading: Two perspectives, one event

Read both short texts. As you read, underline what each perspective values, remembers, or questions.

TEXT A

The traditional story

Focus on harvest, gratitude, family, food, and freedom.

How does this perspective describe the settlers?

TEXT B

The Native American story

Focus on loss, broken promises, land, disease, and trauma.

What does this perspective question?

PERSPECTIVE 1 · TRADITIONAL STORY

The traditional story: a harvest celebration

1. In 1620, English settlers known as the Pilgrims arrived in North America.
2. After a difficult first winter, the Wampanoag people helped them grow corn and catch fish.
3. In autumn 1621, the settlers celebrated a successful harvest and invited the Wampanoag to a feast.
4. Today, Thanksgiving is often connected with gratitude for family, food, and freedom.



PERSPECTIVE 2 · NATIVE AMERICAN STORY

The Native American story: a day of mourning

- For many Native Americans, Thanksgiving is not a happy day.
- Settlers brought diseases that killed many Native people, and later took land and broke promises.
- The peace between the Pilgrims and the Wampanoag did not last.
- Because of this trauma, some Native Americans call Thanksgiving a “Day of Mourning.”
- They believe the traditional story hides painful parts of the past.



Discuss: Can a holiday have two meanings?

1. Why do some Native Americans call Thanksgiving a “Day of Mourning”?

2. Is it right to celebrate a holiday that is painful for some people?

3. How can we listen to another perspective with empathy?

Give a reason. Refer to the reading.





· MUSEUM CURATORS

Mini-project: Create a two-sided exhibit

You are museum curators in Washington, D.C.

01

Choose

Choose three exhibit items or sections.

02

Show

Show both the traditional celebration and the Native American perspective.

03

Explain

Explain why each item belongs in the exhibit.

Prepare a short presentation for the class.